decade. Given inconstancy of policies, these are tendencies that must never be entirely disregarded. After all, a little more than a decade ago, China was making common cause with the US on South Asia. In contrast to China's swing from one extreme to the other, India has maintained a stable and evolutionary approach to the West.

How, when and to what extent India should engage the West is its national prerogative. The expectation that we must conform to the ups and downs of another nation's policy is unrealistic and unjustified. And, of course, previous events have demonstrated that when they so wish, India and China can keep their ties on a positive trajectory and insulated from other relationships. Expressing anxieties about the West should not become a cover to constrain the legitimate interests and choices of the other party. Therefore, when such arguments are advanced, the best response is to place a mirror in the room!

PREPARING FOR A DIFFICULT ERA

India and China are quite distinct in their persona and behaviour, even though they are neighbours. As it is not a command polity, public opinion plays a much greater role in India's perception of its external relationships. It is not only more quickly exercised but when that happens, also slower to forget. Factors like faith and values have a relevance that is not readily appreciated by those who do not share them. Moreover, reactions are less determined by cost–benefit analysis, and perceptions tend to be more permanent. The interplay of internal politics with foreign policy can also be complicated in a democratic and pluralistic society like India. We may be seeing public reversals in the traditional stance of political players who embraced China earlier on matters ranging from security to economics. But transient politics should not let us hide the deeper truths. Insofar as border areas are concerned, the outcomes of 1962 and continuous neglect of the infrastructure have to be effectively addressed through determined responses. And that is exactly the exercise underway.

When it comes to the border, India stands significantly disadvantaged by the topography. The nature of the terrain makes the boundary far harder to secure from the south than from the north. This is further compounded by the outcome of the 1962 war. In many sectors, China vastly benefited by the 38,000 sq. km. territory that it gained during the conflict. In fact, even